InTRACt · Interplay of Text, Reader And Context

The language on the screen: children's reading in a multilingual story app

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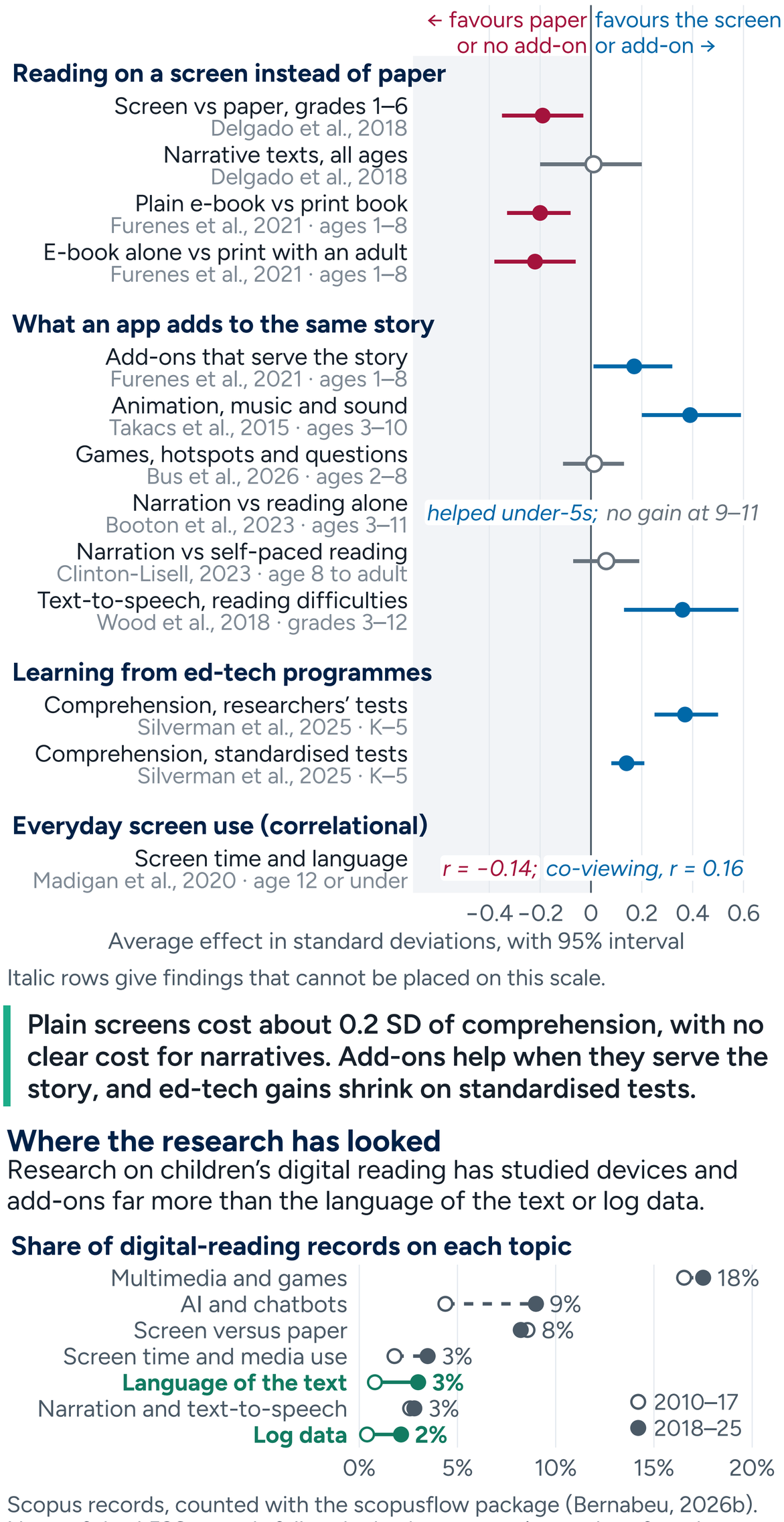
DEPARTMENT OF EDUCATION · UNIVERSITY OF OXFORD

Research has asked whether screens help or hurt children's reading. We ask how the language of on-screen stories shapes reading too.

WHAT WE KNOW

Screens, apps and children's reading

In 2025, more than one in five UK 8- to 18-year-olds read fiction on a screen at least monthly (Picton & Clark, 2026).



Italic rows give findings that cannot be placed on this scale.

Plain screens cost about 0.2 SD of comprehension, with no clear cost for narratives. Add-ons help when they serve the story, and ed-tech gains shrink on standardised tests.

Where the research has looked

Research on children's digital reading has studied devices and add-ons far more than the language of the text or log data.

Scopus records, counted with the scopusflow package (Bernabeu, 2026b). None of the 1,536 records fell under both green topics, and we found no meta-analysis of generative AI and children's reading.

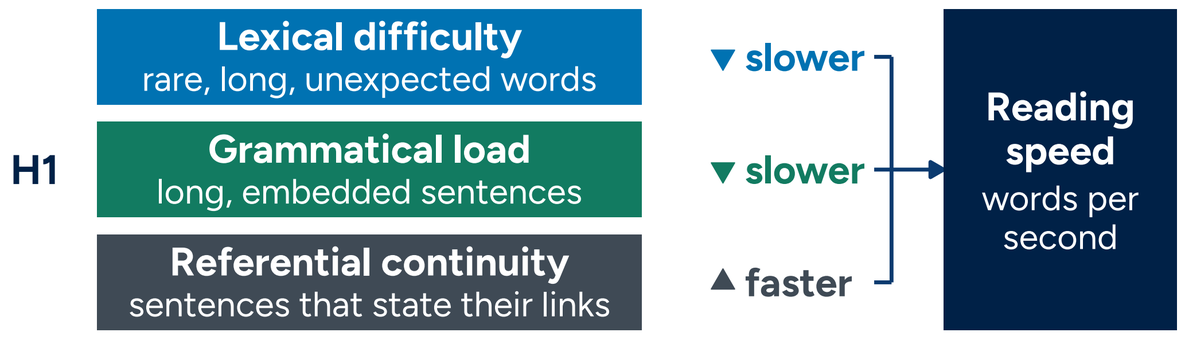
WHAT WE WILL TEST

Using *Let's Story* reading logs in 18 languages, we test whether text features that slow or speed reading in the laboratory do the same in everyday app use.

Let's Story: AI stories, logged at scale

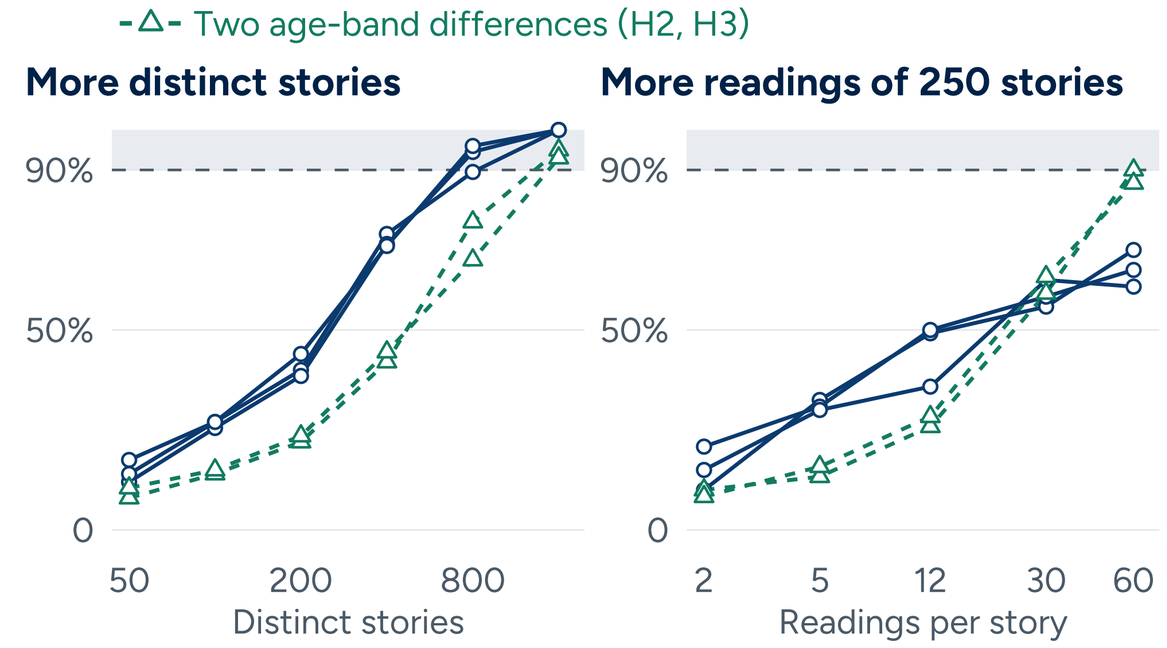
In this app feature, a child picks a hero, companion, setting, plot and theme. A generative model then writes the story (Ratner et al., 2025). In its first month, *Let's Story* logged 419,700 sessions (Ratner & Murphy, 2026).

Six registered hypotheses



H2	**Grammatical** effect, by age band	▲▼ either way
H3	**Continuity** effect, by age band	▲▼ either way
H4	Narration shrinks the **lexical** effect more than the **continuity** effect	
H5	Children rate a story harder when its features slow reading	
H6	More stories read so far	▲ faster

Precision comes from stories, not sessions



Chance of showing that a small effect (0.10 SD) is more than negligible, simulated with the pilotr package (Bernabeu, 2026a). A main effect needs 630–740 distinct stories, or about 930 under the stricter Bayes-factor rule.

Effects that hold in the app could inform how AI stories are pitched to each age band, though faster reading is not better understanding. Effects that fade may reflect home reading conditions or the measure as much as the theory.

A Registered Report on sealed data

1. Peer review before any outcome is seen
2. Logs released only after acceptance
3. Text measures fixed blind to outcomes
4. Decision rules set in advance

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References, protocol and code: tinyurl.com/intract-poster